

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MALI

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Mali's life flows from the Niger River and, above all, from the **Inner Niger Delta** at its heart — one of the world's great inland wetlands, which sustains some one and a half million people, yields the great majority of the nation's fish and half its dry-season livestock, and grows its distinctive floating rice — a lifeline now threatened at once by dams proposed upstream, by the diversion of its water for large-scale irrigation, and by a deepening, climate-driven drought. At the same time, Mali is one of Africa's great gold producers, and its gold, dug both in large industrial mines and by countless small-scale miners across the land, is won with mercury and cyanide that poison the rivers, the soil, and the health of those who live by them. This is a poor nation under military rule and gripped by a grinding conflict, with insecurity across much of its land, armed groups, and real dangers to those who speak out. There is no single victory to be won. But the work can be done, carefully, and the levers are real.

In a poor nation under military rule and gripped by conflict, those who would defend Mali's water and land work carefully, through community, technical, and international channels — and the tools are real. The distinctive lever is the **case against the poison of the gold**: the mercury and cyanide fouling the rivers, soil, and people's health are reached through the global **Minamata mercury framework** and the concrete, non-ideological health evidence — the aim being to clean the gold up, not to end the livelihood of millions. The **Inner Niger Delta that feeds millions** can be defended through the river's shared, transboundary governance — the Niger Basin frameworks — since its threats come partly from dams upstream in another country, and through its **Ramsar wetland** protection. The **livelihoods** the water sustains — the fishing, farming, and herding of a million and a half people — are a powerful, unifying, non-ideological stake. And the **international frameworks and partners**, together with the company and financier standards and the donor leverage a poor, aid-dependent state affords, reach the miners, the companies, and the state. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Gold is a mainstay of the nation and the livelihood of millions, so the poor miners must never be punished — only helped to safer ways. The delta's threats come partly from upstream in another country and from Mali's own need for food and power, beyond its sole control. And — this matters most of all — the nation is poor, under military rule, and beset by insecurity and conflict, with armed groups and real dangers to those who speak out, so the work must be done with the greatest care, through community, technical, and international channels, framed around health, water, and livelihoods, never around challenging authority, and protecting everyone — especially the vulnerable communities and local advocates — absolutely. And no single victory is to be won. So the honest prize is the poison reduced through the mercury framework and the health case, the delta defended through the shared river governance and its wetland status, the livelihoods protected — carefully, through community and international channels, not an open stop. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot mount open confrontation in a nation under military rule and gripped by conflict, and you must never endanger the vulnerable. What can be done, carefully, is to press the concrete, non-ideological case for health, water, and livelihoods: reduce the gold's poison through the global mercury framework and the health evidence; defend the delta that feeds millions through the shared river governance and its wetland status; make the livelihoods of fishers, farmers, and herders the unifying stake; and use the international

frameworks, company standards, and donor leverage — all through community, technical, and international channels, and protecting everyone.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Mali is among the hardest settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. The nation is poor, under military rule, and beset by conflict, with real dangers to those who speak out; gold is the livelihood of millions, so the poor miners cannot be punished; and the delta's threats come partly from upstream and from Mali's own needs. This is not a fight for open confrontation or a single victory. It is careful work through community, technical, and international channels, framed around health, water, and livelihoods, whose realistic prize is the poison reduced, the delta defended, the livelihoods protected — while everyone, especially the vulnerable, is protected absolutely.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with a military government amid conflict, but the decisions a careful effort can reach run through health, water, and international channels: the **mines, environment, and water authorities** that govern the gold and the delta; the **transboundary river bodies** — the Niger Basin frameworks — that shape the delta's water; the **international frameworks and partners** — the mercury and wetland regimes, the donors, the companies' financiers; and the **community and technical experts**. Avoid the conflict and the armed groups, and map who can be reached safely before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A harm — a poisoning gold operation, an upstream dam, an irrigation diversion — advances through the state, the market, and, for the delta, another country upstream. The entry points are the health and mercury case for the gold; the transboundary river governance and the wetland status for the delta; and the international frameworks, company standards, and donor leverage throughout. Enter through the community, technical, and international channels, framed around health and livelihoods, and only where it is safe.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the gold: which mines and miners use the mercury and cyanide, and what the health data shows. Follow the water: which upstream dams and diversions threaten the delta, and what the shared river governance says. Follow the livelihoods: the fishing, farming, and herding the water sustains. Follow the finance: which companies, financiers, and donors reach the harm. The leverage lies in the mercury framework, the transboundary and wetland frameworks, and the livelihoods stake.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is weak under military rule and conflict, but the mines, environment, and water authorities, the transboundary river bodies, the global mercury and wetland frameworks, the donors and financiers, and the community and technical experts are the channels a careful case engages — holding each, on health, water, and livelihoods, to the frameworks and the evidence.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Malian effort openly halts a harm in a nation under military rule and conflict, and honesty requires saying so. What the careful, non-ideological tools can deliver is the poison reduced, the delta defended, the livelihoods protected. The single most decisive move is **the concrete health-and-livelihoods case, carried through the international frameworks**, because mercury poisoning the water and the loss of a delta that feeds millions are non-ideological harms the global frameworks and donors can act on, and because they can be pressed without open confrontation. The mercury framework is the distinctive lever; the transboundary and wetland frameworks the delta's defence; the livelihoods the unifying stake; the international partners the reach. The realistic prize is real, pursued carefully and safely.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the gold's mercury and cyanide, the upstream dam or diversion threatening the delta, the drought's compounding. **What framework reaches it?** — the global mercury regime, the transboundary river governance, the wetland status. **What is the health or livelihood stake?** — the poisoned water, the fishery, the herding, the floating rice. **Which channel is safe?** — the community, technical, or international one, clear of the conflict. **How is everyone kept safe, and the poor not punished?** — the overriding questions. Pick the harm where a framework and a safe channel give the clearest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, carefully. **Layer one: the harm** — the mercury and cyanide in the water and people, the delta's shrinking flood, the lost livelihoods, documented with the health and hydrological science where it is safe. **Layer two: the framework and the standard** — the global mercury regime, the transboundary river governance, the Ramsar wetland status, the company and donor standards. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which international, technical, or community body to reach, and the absolute discipline of avoiding the conflict, protecting the vulnerable, and never punishing the poor miners. A case built on the non-ideological health and livelihood harm and the international frameworks is one that can move a troubled state, safely.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the mercury and cyanide data, the health effects, the delta's shrinking flood, the lost fish, livestock, and rice. Gather the **framework record**: the global mercury regime, the transboundary river governance, the Ramsar wetland status, the company and donor standards. Gather the **livelihood record**: the fishing, farming, and herding the water sustains. Gather the **channel record**: the international partners, the technical experts, the community. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work avoids the conflict, protects the vulnerable, and never targets the poor.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE COMMUNITY, TECHNICAL & INTERNATIONAL COALITION

The coalition here is careful, community-based, and international. Build it from the **fishing, farming, herding, and mining communities**, whose health, water, and livelihoods are at stake, kept safe; the **technical and health experts** who hold the mercury and hydrological data; the **international frameworks**,

donors, and partners reaching a poor, aid-dependent state; and the **companies' financiers** who carry standards. Frame everything around health, water, and livelihoods, never around challenging authority; protect individuals absolutely, especially the vulnerable communities and any local advocate; and never turn the effort against the poor miners — help them to safer ways.

STEP 4: THE MERCURY CASE, THE DELTA'S DEFENCE & THE FRAMEWORKS — CONTESTING THE HARM SAFELY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by poverty, military rule, and conflict, so the prize is the poison reduced, the delta defended, the livelihoods protected — carefully.

The Mercury Case

The distinctive lever is the **case against the poison of the gold** — the mercury and cyanide fouling the water, soil, and health — reached through the global **Minamata mercury framework** and the concrete health evidence. The aim is to clean the gold up, not to end the livelihood of millions, so the case is for safer ways, never bans on the poor.

The Delta's Defence

The **Inner Niger Delta** can be defended through the river's shared, **transboundary governance** — the Niger Basin frameworks — since its threats come partly from dams upstream in another country, and through its **Ramsar wetland** protection. Press the shared river governance and the wetland status to defend the flood that feeds millions.

The Livelihoods and the International Frameworks

The **livelihoods** of the fishers, farmers, and herders are a powerful, unifying, non-ideological stake, and the **international frameworks, donors, and company standards** reach a poor, aid-dependent state and its miners and companies. Pursued together — the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, and the frameworks — these levers reduce the poison and defend the delta, carefully, while protecting everyone.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always to health, water, and livelihoods. **For the mercury framework:** here is the poison in the water and people, to be reduced through safer ways. **For the transboundary river bodies:** here is a delta feeding millions threatened by upstream dams. **For the wetland status:** here is a Ramsar wetland under threat. **For the donors and financiers:** here is a company or project failing your standards. **For the communities:** here is the water and livelihood we share, and the safer ways to protect them. **The golden rule:** ground everything in the non-ideological health and livelihood harm and the international frameworks, keep it careful and safe, protect the vulnerable, and never punish the poor miners.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care in a nation under military rule and conflict, and largely through international and technical channels. Frame any attention around **health, water, and livelihoods:** the poison in the water, the delta that feeds millions, the fishers and herders at stake — never around challenging authority. Carry it through the international frameworks, the technical and conservation outlets, and the donor channels, never through anything that endangers anyone or touches the conflict. A few

cautions govern everything: never expose the vulnerable; frame it around health and livelihoods; protect everyone; never blame the poor miners; and let the mercury and hydrological evidence carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message careful, framed on health, water, and livelihoods, and protective of everyone.

8A — To the mercury framework or partners: document the mercury and cyanide poisoning and press for safer ways, not bans.

8B — To the transboundary river bodies: set out the upstream threat to the delta that feeds millions.

8C — On the wetland: invoke the Ramsar status of the Inner Niger Delta.

8D — To a donor or financier: flag a company or project failing your environmental and health standards.

8E — To a technical or health expert: request the mercury and hydrological assessment.

8F — On the livelihoods: set out the fishing, farming, and herding at stake, and the safer ways to protect them.

8G — To the community: set out the shared health and water stake and organise safely.

8H — To the international public: summarise the poison and the threatened delta, and ask for support — without exposing anyone or blaming the poor.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the mercury poisoning or the delta threat and the livelihoods at stake; write the one-page health-and-livelihoods case; identify the safe international or technical channel. **The fastest-moving levers:** the mercury framework, the transboundary and wetland frameworks, and the donor and company standards. **Emergency action:** for the gold's poison, the mercury framework and health case; for the delta, the shared river governance and wetland status. Throughout, avoid the conflict, protect the vulnerable, and never punish the poor miners.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but troubled and dangerous: military rule, conflict, insecurity, and a delta threatened partly from beyond Mali's borders. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not an open stop, but the poison reduced, the delta defended, the livelihoods protected. Lean on the levers the trouble cannot easily reach: the global mercury framework, the transboundary and wetland regimes, the donor and company standards, the international partners. And accept the honest limits — the gold sustains millions, the delta's threats are partly external, the danger is real — while still pressing the health-and-livelihoods case, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In a nation under military rule and conflict, the dangers include the armed groups, the insecurity, and any who profit from the poisoning gold or the diverted water. Respond only through the **careful and international channels:** the mercury framework, the transboundary and wetland regimes, the donor and

company standards, the documented record. Never through open confrontation or anything touching the conflict or the armed groups. **On safety and care:** this note matters most of all here. Mali is under military rule and gripped by conflict, with real dangers to those who speak out. Favour the community, technical, and international channels over open confrontation; protect individuals absolutely, especially the vulnerable communities and local advocates; frame the work around health, water, and livelihoods, never around challenging authority; and never punish the poor miners. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, carefully and largely through international and technical channels. The documented harm feeds the mercury case, the delta's defence, and the framework appeals at once; the community, technical, and international coalition organises safely alongside; any attention runs through the frameworks and donors. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the poison or the delta threat and the livelihoods; **months two to six**, press the mercury framework, the transboundary and wetland regimes, and the donors and companies; **beyond**, sustain the careful defence of the water and health. The core discipline: health- and livelihood-grounded, framework-carried, safe, and protective of the vulnerable.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Mali is among the hardest and most dangerous grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a harm can be openly stopped under military rule and conflict, or that the poor miners can be punished for a gold trade that sustains millions, or that a single victory exists — none of that is true, and the danger to those who speak out is real. What it claims is narrower and real: that the mercury and cyanide poisoning the water and people can be reduced through the global mercury framework and the health evidence, toward safer ways rather than bans; that the Inner Niger Delta that feeds millions can be defended through the shared, transboundary river governance and its Ramsar wetland status; that the livelihoods of fishers, farmers, and herders are a powerful, unifying stake; and that the international frameworks, donors, and company standards reach a poor, aid-dependent state. The levers are careful, community-based, and international, and the prize is the poison reduced, the delta defended, the livelihoods protected — not an open stop. For a poor, troubled, delta-fed nation, that careful work — framed around health, water, and livelihoods, protecting the vulnerable, and never punishing the poor — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.